

OCD

No other mental disorder hides as stealthily, delays diagnosis, or causes as much embarrassed suffering as obsessive compulsive disorder. But better treatments are breaking its hold.

■ **By Damayanti Datta**

It's off, it's off," he mutters, staring hard at the gas cooker. He is slinking around the house at the dead of night, battling with his inner demons and checking again and again all the "dangerous" things that might put his family's safety at stake. He places his hand on each burner and counts 10 to make sure it's cold. Did he hear footsteps? If his wife catches him she'll just yell, "Go to bed!" But she doesn't understand the mind-numbing,

searing anxiety that cripples him every night. He loses concentration and starts checking all over again. Fifteen minutes later, he heads towards the toaster. Is it unplugged at the wall? Time to check out the microwave and the iron. An hour later, spent and ashamed, he tiptoes back to bed. He knows he will do it all over again, tomorrow.

Tomorrow dawns bright and busy at the National Institute of Mental Health and Neuro Sciences (NIMHANS) in Bangalore. The convention centre is chock-a-block with experts from

across the nation and the world. In that swirl of people, Dr Y. C. Janardhan Reddy is gnawed by nerves. After all, the international symposium on Obsessive Compulsive Disorder (OCD) is an ode to 10 years of backbreaking labour at India's first OCD clinic. "Until recently, it was seen as a rare disorder," says Reddy, additional professor and consultant with the clinic. Now it's one of the top 10 debilitating diseases, reports the World Health Organisation (WHO). Over 12 million Indians are thought to have it in one form or an-